

Comparative Ethical Leadership Analysis: Mahatma Gandhi and Aung San Suu Kyi

Introduction

Popularity, influence, and success are usually used as criteria of leadership. Such attributes are however not sufficient to make a leader ethical. The leader can be respected and might have authority but at the same time make morally flawed decisions. Ethical leadership is rather evaluated according to the concepts of truth, accountability, justice, integrity, authenticity, effective communications, strategic thinking and dedication to something larger than oneself. These concepts enable us to realize that leadership does not entail the acquisition of support or preservation of power, but doing something that honors human dignity.

In this paper, I compare Mahatma Gandhi of Column A and Aung San Suu Kyi of Column B. In the case of Gandhi, I want to concentrate on the Salt March, the spirit of satyagraha, which I highly concur as it is associated with sacrifice, truth, and non-violent resistance to injustice. In the case of Aung San Suu Kyi, I concentrate on the 2019 defence of Myanmar at the International Court of Justice, which I find ethically objectionable since it prioritised the protection of the state over the truth, accountability and suffering of the Rohingya. This paper will argue that the Salt March is an ethical leadership approach due to the reasons that Gandhi was acting based on the truth, non-violence, sacrifice, and justice, while Aung San Suu Kyi at the ICJ is an unethical leadership style due to the reasons that she was acting on behalf of the state protection rather than accountability, integrity, and human suffering.

Summary of the Article

The point of this analogy is that fame or position should not be the only criteria of judging the leadership. An ethical leader ought to be a person of integrity, that is, his or her behavior should be in line with their values. The leader must also have authenticity

where he does what he requests others to do. Communication and vision are important issues since great leaders can make simple happenings significant causes. Meanwhile, immoral strategic thinking will be hazardous when it defends power rather than right.

The Gandhi article is a representation of anti-colonial resistance as a political struggle, but it is also an ethical struggle. “It describes how the Salt March of 1930 faced the challenge of the British salt monopoly and salt tax by nonviolent opposition, as opposed to revenge and violence” (Satia, 2022).

The BBC News (2019) on Aung San Suu Kyi demonstrates a completely different vision of leadership. It says that at the ICJ she defended Myanmar in genocide-related accusations, termed the case unfinished and erroneous, and termed the violence in Rakhine as an inner armed conflict with the result of a 2017 army crackdown killing numerous Rohingya and displacing over 700,000 people into Bangladesh. “She justified the military of Myanmar against the accusations of mass murder, rape, and deportation of Rohingya, claiming that the intent of genocide could not be presupposed and that the case was highly multifaceted (Al Jazeera, 2019).”

The three sources will serve the foundation of a comparison between two extremely different types of leadership. The case of Gandhi brings out integrity, authenticity, ethical sacrifice and visionary communication. The case of Suu Kyi elevates the issue of strategy abuse, loss of moral responsibility and what occurs when truth and human dignity is consumed.

Application to the Real-World Case

Mahatma Gandhi

The Salt March by Mahatma Gandhi is one of the most obvious examples of ethical leadership. “In 1930 Gandhi led a 25-day, 240-mile march to protest the British salt monopoly and tax, and this campaign involved mass participation as the man addressed people during the way” (Satia, 2022). This was an act of politics, but it was

also very ethical since Gandhi opposed injustice but he never employed hatred or violence.

I support the move made by Gandhi since it demonstrates that ethical leadership is not only goal-specific, but approach-specific as well. “The article describes the fact that Gandhian non co-operation was constructed upon sacrifice and act of morality in the now, rather than by employing immorality in a future payoff” (Satia, 2022). This is an act of integrity since whatever Gandhi did corresponded to his principles. It is also authentic as he did not request people to suffer on his behalf and remained safe himself.

Gandhi was also effective in communication and vision. Salt was a common thing but he made it a great symbol of pride, freedom and injustice by the colonialists. Such leadership is not all protest. It is assisting people to find a larger meaning in daily oppression and mobilizing them around a moral struggle.

“The article even continues by stating that satyagrahis were not only ready to be deprived, receive violent punishment, imprisoned, and even die to bring the suppressed humanity to the fore of their oppressors” (Satia, 2022). This is the reason why I find the leadership ethically sound of Gandhi. He was engaged in something greater than himself and his opposition was influenced by truth and moral responsibility and not revenge. He desired freedom, however, he also desired a kind of freedom that would not ruin human values along the way.

The other fact that made me agree with the leadership of Gandhi is that it was directly related to the common folks. Elite politics were not the only concern of the Salt March. It revolved around a day-to-day need and demonstrated the impact of colonialism on ordinary lives. Due to this fact, the leadership of Gandhi was symbolic and practical. It honored the dignity of people as it opened them into a bigger cause.

In general, the Salt March by Gandhi is an ethical leadership style since it embodies truth, sacrifice, integrity, authenticity, and definite moral intent. Domination was not a basis of his leadership. It was based upon disciplined bravery.

Aung San Suu Kyi

On the contrary, the Myanmar defence that was given by Aung San Suu Kyi at the ICJ was unethical. According to the BBC News (2019) report shows that she justified Myanmar against the genocide charges, asserted the case to be complete and fallacious and that the Rakhine violence was an internal armed conflict but not genocide. “Thousands of Rohingya were slaughtered and over 700,000 displaced to the neighbors in Bangladesh in the 2017 army crackdown” (BBC News, 2019).

She also justified Myanmar military to include actions of mass killings, rape, and expelling Rohingya Muslim minority. It further reports that she said that “the intent of genocide was not the sole one, that the military might have used disproportional force and that the circumstances were a complicated conflict and not an effort to exterminate the minority group” (Al Jazeera, 2019).

The ethically wrong thing about this decision is that it put the protection of the state higher than the sufferings of the people who were underprivileged. Accountability, honesty and respect for truth should be included in ethical leadership. In this case, however, the influence exerted by Suu Kyi seemed to be that of trying to repair the reputation of Myanmar rather than just address the situation of the Rohingya. That can be evidence of political thinking, but not leadership in terms of ethics.

Such a case is particularly dramatic since Suu Kyi had been a well-established international icon of democracy and moral opposition. According to the BBC News (2019) report, she was a champion of democracy at one time, but she subsequently defended the very army that had previously placed her on house arrest and had been implicated in the military clearances herself. This poses a major issue of authenticity. One of the former emissaries of human rights was seen to be defending a system that was accused of atrocious crimes.

“This is an even more serious issue to a Bangladeshi. According to the report, over 700,000 Rohingya were forced to flee to Bangladesh and that refugees in Kutupalong observed her defence in Cox's Bazar and responded angrily and disbelievingly” (BBC

News, 2019). The Al Jazeera (2019) report also mentions that over 730, 000 Rohingya had fled Myanmar and that most of them were residing in overcrowded refugee camps in Bangladesh. It is due to this that the decision made by Suu Kyi can never be regarded as a far-off diplomatic happening on our side. It directly affected the region and humanitarian impacts.

I therefore perceive her defence to be a failure of leadership ethics. It was not honest since her move was contrary to the democratic and human-rights reputation she was reputed to be. It was not real since her public image could no longer be linked to the moral principles that were identified with her name. It also failed to commit itself to human dignity since the misery of the victims was shadowed by the protection by the states.

Reflection and Analysis

The comparison of Gandhi and Suu Kyi made me realize that ethical leadership is most put to the tune during the conflict situations. The example of Gandhi indicates that a leader does not need to sacrifice morality by combating injustice. His leadership is also indicative of integrity since his actions were in accordance with what he preached. It is real since he himself experienced the sacrifice he was requesting the others to go through. It is also indicative of visionary thinking since he was able to turn a very basic problem such as salt into a sign of justice and freedom.

The case of Suu Kyi taught me the lesson opposite. A leader can continue to be in power, have influence and international recognition, but as far as truth and human suffering are sidelined, he or she may fail. Defending her at the ICJ can be considered as politically strategic, yet the strategy is not sufficient. Lack of moral accountability by leadership is a serious compromise to leadership.

This analogy also assisted me in considering the distinction between effective leadership and ethical leadership. A leader is able to speak effectively, handle the pressure of the people and defend the interests of the state and such abilities are very harmful when they are not linked to the truth and justice. This is the reason why

strategic thinking or communication toolkit should not be praised independently. The values they serve should be the judgment of them.

In his own self, Gandhi provides a better example of a leader since he demonstrates that force is not always more effective than righteousness. He was against a great empire, but with human dignity, he adopted the means. Instead, the case of Suu Kyi demonstrates how a leadership can fail when an individual defends power more than the citizens. As a South Asian and a Bangladeshi, that lesson seems even put into particular focus due to the fact that the crisis of Rohingya is not a historic event in our lives. We live in our regional reality.

Conclusion

To summarize, Aung San Suu Kyi and Mahatma Gandhi are two very contrasting types of leadership as far as their ethical approach is concerned. Ethical leadership is manifested in Gandhi Salt March, which was a mixture of truth, sacrifice, integrity, authenticity, quality communication and devotion to the cause other than personal relish. His example shows that justice might not always be inhumane..

The act by Aung San Suu Kyi of defending Myanmar in the ICJ is unethical leadership because she considered state security, as opposed to being responsible, telling the truth, and the situation of the Rohingya. Her example shows that the reputation and the political positions are not able to guarantee the moral leadership. This analogy demonstrates that leaders cannot be evaluated within the context of the influence and success only, but should the judgment be the one that advances the human dignity in the most required moments.

References

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